

Chapter III--SCOTCH HISTORY 1000-1400AD [and Beyond]

A.GENERAL CHARACTER OF THE PERIOD. The dates for the start and end of this period were chosen here fairly arbitrarily and mainly for convenience in study. The general tone of the times could be given in the words of the 3 sisters in Shakespeare's MacBeth as they hobbled around their sinister cauldron on the heath:

*Double, double, toil and trouble,
Fire burn, and cauldron bubble.*

During these 4 centuries the fire that burned without ceasing was the flaming ambition of men, families and parties as they carried on their frenzied struggle for power. The stench of intrigue and murder became only more rank and foul. There were 5 main elements or factions which were jockeying or fighting among themselves for supreme power:

The Scottish Kings, several of whom tried to establish dynasties on firm foundations, but did not succeed.

The English monarchs who missed no chance to meddle in the affairs of Scotland.

Invading Norseman who now sought, with some success, to set up permanent dominions in Western Scotland and Ireland.

Lords of the Isles, a line of Scotch nobles who tried to repel marauding Norsemen and limit royal power in the Highlands.

The various Clans and Chiefs who although they cooperated at times, insisted on retaining their freedom and independence.

B.Duncan and MacBeth. Malcolm II, son of Kenneth III, roundly defeated the Northumbrians at Carham in 1018 and after this Scottish rule gradually extended to the River Tweed. Duncan, the grandson and heir of Malcolm II, began his reign with the largest domain a Scotch King had up to that time. But his heyday was not long as he was defeated by both Norsemen and Northumbrians and in 1040 was slain by his own general, MacBeth.

MacBeth's ancestry has provoked much disagreement among historians, but Skene's "Genealogy of the Clan Quarry" listed MacBeth in the Quarry lineage. Some put him in both the house of Loarn and of the Alpinian line, but Douglas states he was not of the Alpine line, but a usurper.

The tragic story of MacBeth killing King Duncan while a guest in MacBeth's castle, told by Shakespeare, is widely known and needs no repetition. However the kinships might be interesting to MacQuarries and the killings are typical of the brutal times. Duncan's mother was Bethoc and her sister Doda was MacBeth's mother. The 2 sisters were daughters of Malcolm II; thus Duncan and MacBeth were cousins. MacBeth's father, Findlaech, was never king. It seems Lady MacBeth was also related to the MacQuarries.

Lady Macbeth, named Gruoch, was the daughter of Boete, the son of Kenneth IV, last male scion of the Alpine line of Kings. In 1003 Kenneth IV attacked Malcolm II, was defeated and killed, and Malcolm became king. In 1029, Malcolm II helped slay his son-in-law, Findlaech, MacBeth's father. Further, in 1032 he murdered Gruoch's brother and also burned alive her husband, Gilcomgain. It is understandable that the 2 MacBeths might have bad feelings about Duncan whose grandfather had visited so much